CHAPTER 22 Cabinet Committees

The Cabinet works through various committees. These committees are called as Cabinet Committees. The features, list and functions of these committees are explained below.

FEATURES OF CABINET COMMITTEES

The following are the features of Cabinet Committees:

1. They are extra-constitutional in emergence. In other words, they are not mentioned in the Constitution. However, the Rules of Business provide for their establishment.

2. They are of two types—standing and *ad hoc*. The former are of a permanent nature while the latter are of a temporary nature. The *ad hoc* committees are constituted from time to time to deal with special problems. They are disbanded after their task is completed.[1]

3. They are set up by the Prime Minister according to the exigencies of the time and requirements of the situation. Hence, their number, nomenclature, and composition varies from time to time.

4. Their membership varies from one committee to another committee. They usually include only Cabinet Ministers. Sometimes, the non-cabinet ministers can also be appointed as their members. Further, the non-cabinet ministers can also attend the meetings of the Cabinet Committees as special invitees.

5. They not only include the Ministers in charge of subjects covered by them but also include other senior Ministers.

6. They are mostly headed by the Prime Minister. Some times other senior Cabinet Ministers also acts as their Chairman. But, in case the Prime Minister is a member of a committee, he/she invariably presides over it.

7. They not only sort out issues and formulate proposals for the consideration of the Cabinet, but also take decisions. However, the Cabinet can review their decisions.

8. They are an organisational device to reduce the enormous workload of the Cabinet. They also facilitate in-depth examination of policy issues and effective coordination. They are based on the principles of division of labour and effective delegation.

LIST OF CABINET COMMITTEES

At present, the following 8 Cabinet Committees are functional:

1. Cabinet Committee on Political Affairs

2. Cabinet Committee on Economic Affairs

3. Appointments Committee of the Cabinet

4. Cabinet Committee on Parliamentary Affairs